



K. Keerthivasan

keerthivasan.k@thehindu.co.in

'People Make Glasgow' is the Scottish city's official tourism slogan. For India, though, it may well be athletics, boxing and weightlifting that will make the country stand tall at the truncated 2026 Commonwealth Games, to be held in the host city from July 23 to August 2 across four venues.

Unlike athletics, which arrives with a glittering cast of Paris Olympic medallists and 2025 World Championship winners, boxing and weightlifting may not boast the same galaxy of global superstars. But that could work in India's favour. With several genuine medal contenders of its own and a formidable Commonwealth pedigree, India has a golden opportunity to make every punch and every lift count.

India has traditionally been one of the strongest boxing nations at the Commonwealth Games, with the sport evolving into one of the country's most dependable medal factories.

At the 2014 Glasgow Games, Indian boxers returned with five medals. The high point came at Gold Coast 2018, where India claimed nine medals, including three gold.

At Birmingham 2022, the boxing team once again delivered a rich haul of seven medals. A similar return of around six to eight medals will be the expectation in Glasgow.

But the road to the podium will be anything but straightforward.

In women's boxing, India will encounter several quality opponents, including England's Chantelle Reid and Australian challengers Emma-Sue Greentree and Lekeisha Pergoliti, among others. These are fighters capable of turning a bout on its head and will test India's medal

Firm favourite: Mirabai Chanu is in excellent form and will be aiming to complete a historic hat-trick of CWG gold medals and a fourth overall.

VIJAY SONEJI

ambitions.

The men's field may not feature as many household names, but it will be packed with dangerous and hungry contenders. England's Paddy Hewitt (70kg) and Northern Ireland's Jude Gallagher, the 2022 Commonwealth Games champion, will compete in the 60kg category. There are also several promising boxers from Canada, Australia and New Zealand with the skills and temperament to spring surprises when it matters most.

Weightlifting, too, promises an intense battle.

The 2025 Commonwealth Weightlifting Championships, which served as a direct qualification